

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Food when cooking is unavailable

FIELD SKILLS / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Use safe ready-to-eat food, protect drinking water and keep hands and utensils clean. Do not run a camping stove, grill or charcoal indoors. Check food-storage times and temperatures after power loss; never taste suspect food to decide whether it is safe. Plan around dietary and medical needs.

Do now.

- ☐ **Inventory safe food**
01 Count shelf-stable items that can be eaten without heating and identify a manual opener. Separate suspect refrigerated food from safe supplies.
- ☐ **Plan small portions**
02 Open only what can be eaten safely when refrigeration is unavailable. Read the label for storage after opening.
- ☐ **Protect water and hygiene**
03 Use safe water for food and essential washing. Keep preparation surfaces separate from toilet waste and dirty containers.
- ☐ **Keep combustion outside**
04 Use cooking equipment only in the location and manner its instructions allow. Never burn charcoal or use a camp stove inside a room, garage or enclosed balcony.
- ☐ **Include special needs**
05 Plan for infants, allergies, diabetes, swallowing difficulty and pets. Do not change prescribed diets or infant formula preparation without qualified advice.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Use known safe shelf-stable food already present and a written meal inventory. If no safe cooking position exists, choose food that does not need cooking rather than improvising an indoor flame.

Watch for.

Food that looks and smells normal can still be unsafe. Do not salvage leaking, swollen or flood-contaminated packaging.

People & practical needs.

Assign portions around actual dietary needs and available safe drinking water. A manual opener should be usable by the person preparing food. Keep pet food and special feeding supplies included rather than assuming a generic emergency meal works for everyone.

Keep essentials within reach.

Prioritize supplies named in this guide that are usable by the person who needs them. Keep the checklist and relevant contact details accessible. Check carrying capacity, storage and equipment instructions in advance; collecting equipment must not delay the immediate protective action.

Next decisions.

Replenish through a verified reachable source before supplies become critical. Set aside easy-to-carry food for movement and avoid creating a plan that depends entirely on fuel or refrigeration.

Check the next usable option

Replenish through a verified reachable source before supplies become critical. Set aside easy-to-carry food for movement and avoid creating a plan that depends entirely on fuel or refrigeration.

When the first option is unavailable

Use known safe shelf-stable food already present and a written meal inventory. If no safe cooking position exists, choose food that does not need cooking rather than improvising an indoor flame.

Questions in the field.

Can everyone eat the stored food?

Check allergies, chewing or swallowing limitations, infant feeding and the need for safe water. Prefer foods the household already eats. A no-cook food still needs safe storage and handling after opening.

What if there is no safe refrigeration?

Choose shelf-stable portions that can be used without keeping unsafe leftovers. Keep opened food away from heat, insects and contamination. Do not make a meal plan depend on a working refrigerator when power is uncertain.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Food safety after power loss · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/food-safety/foods/keep-food-safe-after-emergency.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/guides/food-without-cooking/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.